Ararat Gocmen

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Labor, Finance, Migration, Entrepreneurship

DOCTORAL STUDIES

University College London (UCL) – PhD in Economics 2027 (expected)
Dissertation: "Essays in Labor and Finance"
Supervisors and references:

Christian Dustmann
Professor of Economics
University College London
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Uta Schönberg
Professor of Economics
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Saleem Bahaj
Professor of Economics and Finance
University College London
Drayton House, 204
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Clara Martínez-Toledano
Assistant Professor of Finance
Imperial College London
Business School Building, 4.03a
South Kensington Campus
London, UK SW7 2AZ
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PRIOR EDUCATION

University College London and Queen Mary University of London 2021
MA in History of Political Thought and Intellectual History, distinction

University College London 2020
MSc in Economics, distinction

Princeton University 2017
BA in History, *summa cum laude*

PERSONAL INFORMATION

Citizenship: United States of America
Languages: English, Armenian, Turkish (native); French, Italian (intermediate); German (beginner)
Skills: Stata, MATLAB, Python, R, SQL

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

ROCKWOOL Foundation Berlin (RFBerlin) – Research Fellow 2026-persent
Centre for Research and Analysis of Migration (CReAM) – Research Officer 2020-present
BlackRock – Analyst, Portfolio Analytics Group 2017-2019
European Roma Rights Centre – Legal Intern 2015

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

ECON0121 – Economic History: BSc, Professor Ramin Nassehi 2024-2026
ECON0062 – Topics in Labor Economics: MSc, Professor Christian Dustmann 2023-2024
ECON0050 – Economics of the Public Sector: BSc, Professors Silvia Dal Bianco and Lucas Conwell 2022-2023

AWARDS, GRANTS, HONORS & SCHOLARSHIPS

Best Paper Award in Labor and Public Economics, Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society-China	2026
PhD Scholarship (£20,000), UCL Stone Centre	2025
Peggy and Richard Musgrave Prize for Best Paper, International Institute of Public Finance	2025
Adam Smith Fellowship, Mercatus Center	2024
External Research Support Grant (£50,000), UCL Stone Centre	2023
Top-Performing MSc Student Prize in Economics, UCL	2020
Outstanding MSc Dissertation Prize in Economics, UCL	2020
Marshall Scholarship	2019
Phi Betta Kappa Society	2017
Gamma Kappa Alpha National Italian Honor Society	2017
Laurence Hutton Prize for the Strongest Record in the Department of History, Princeton University	2017
Walter Phelps Hall Senior Thesis Prize in European History, Princeton University	2017
André Maman Senior Thesis Prize in French History, Princeton University	2017
Shapiro Prize for Academic Excellence, Princeton University	2015

INVITED PRESENTATIONS

2026 – University Carlos III of Madrid Applied Seminar, Armenian Economic Association Young Scholar Workshop, Centre for the Analysis of Taxation Capital Gains Tax Workshop, Norwegian Centre for Taxation Seminar, UCL SPP Migration Cluster and ETH Immigration Policy Lab Workshop on Immigration and Political Behavior, Armenian Economic Association Annual Meeting, CSEF-CEPR Conference on Labor and Finance, Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society-China, World Inequality Conference, Migration and Organizations Conference, UCL Centre for Finance Research Half Day, RFBerlin Migration Forum.

2025 – ESMT Berlin and IWH Labor and Finance Group Fall Conference, CEPR Paris Symposium, UCL Applied Microeconomics PhD Research Day, NBER Public Economics Program Fall Meeting, Northern Finance Association Annual Meeting, European Economic Association Annual Congress, NBER Summer Institute Household Finance, Eleventh Conference of the Society for the Study of Economic Inequality, Armenian Economic Association Annual Meeting, EU Tax Observatory and IEB Workshop on the Economics of Taxation, European Association of Young Economists Annual Meeting, Lake District Workshop in Corporate Finance, RFBerlin Migration Forum

2024 – Asian and Australasian Society of Labor Economics Conference, Madrid Public Economics Workshop.

INVITED PROGRAMS

Visits to MIT and UBC Stone Centers	2026
NBER Entrepreneurship Research Boot Camp	2025
UC Berkeley Stone Center Summer Institute	2023

JOB MARKET PAPER

"Immigration and Firm Investment" – Presented at the Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society-China

In neoclassical models of immigration's long-run effects, capital adjustment shields incumbent workers from losses by counteracting the decline in the marginal productivity of labor. This paper argues that, by inhibiting this adjustment, credit-market frictions amplify the negative wage and employment effects of immigration. I develop a model in which monopsonistic firms with higher initial debt burdens face endogenously steeper financing-cost curves. As a result, immigrant inflows decrease capital intensity, wages, and native employment by more at initially higher-leverage firms. I test these predictions using a custom link between German firms' financial statements and social security records. I first document that, in Germany during the 2010s, a large immigration shock coincided with a sharp decline in firms' capital intensity, and that the borrowing costs of initially higher-leverage firms were more sensitive to additional debt. Exploiting variation in the settlement patterns of earlier immigrants, I find that firms' immigrant hiring responses did not vary by their initial leverage. However, initially higher-leverage firms experienced sharper declines in their capital intensity, wages, and native employment, consistent with my model's predictions. My results imply that credit-market frictions are an underexplored determinant of how the economy absorbs labor supply shocks.

WORKING PAPERS

"Private Capital Markets and Inequality" – Revise and Resubmit, ***American Economic Review*** (SSRN, VoxEU)

with Clara Martínez-Toledano (Imperial College Business School) and Vrinda Mittal (UNC Kenan-Flagler Business School)

This paper examines how expanding private capital markets contribute to rising economic inequalities in the US. We show that the share of early-stage financing raised from US high-net-worth individuals (HNWIs) tripled from 2004 to 2022. Exploiting the expansion of the qualified small business stock (QSBS) long-term capital gains tax exclusion, we find that HNWIs' investments made startups 5.6% more likely to stay private. Counterfactual simulations reveal that HNWIs' excess returns on early-stage investments explain 26% of the growth in the top 0.5% wealth share over 2010-2022. Finally, investor entry increased incumbents' returns and encouraged further investments, generating a self-reinforcing feedback loop between private capital market growth and inequality.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

"Immigration and Labor Market Tightness" – Presented at the Sixth World Labor Conference

with Thomas Cornelissen (University of Essex), Christian Dustmann (UCL), and Uta Schönberg (University of Hong Kong)

This paper demonstrates how the effects of immigration on native workers' employment and wages depend on labor market conditions. Based on a model of the labor market with matching frictions, we first predict that immigration's effect on native employment is less negative in an initially tighter labor market, while its effect on native wages is more negative. We then test these predictions in the context of Germany during the 2010s, exploiting variation in annual immigration shocks to local labor markets interacted with variation across both space and time in the initial tightness of these markets. We find that tightness attenuated immigration's negative employment effects more than it amplified immigration's negative wage effects, evidence that is consistent with our model's predictions and has important implications for the design and timing of immigration reforms.

"Overidentification Tests for Linear IV Models in Practice" – Presented at the Fourth CeMMAP PhD Research Day

with Yuxuan Ren (UCL) and Liyang Sun (UCL)

This paper reviews the overidentification tests available to applied researchers, offers guidance about which tests are appropriate in which settings, and introduces ways to more easily implement tests, which we show to be more robust, based on the objective function of the continuously updating generalized method of moments (CUE) estimator.

PREDOCTORAL RESEARCH

"Before Class Struggle: Inequality in European Political and Economic Thought from More to Marx" – Presented at the London Inequality Workshop, 2023

"*Hay*, *Yabancı*, *Mensch*: National Difference and Multinational Society in the Political Thought of Armenian Workers from Turkey in Postwar Germany" – Presented at the Princeton University Department of Near Eastern Studies Turkish Language Talk, 2022

"Otto Bauer's 'National-Evolutionary Politics': Cultural Nationalism as Socialist Strategy in Hapsburg Austria" – Presented at the Twelfth Annual London Graduate Conference in the History of Political Thought, 2021

"The Age of Extremes in Colonial Context: The Mass Politics of Left and Right in the Department of Alger, 1935-1939" – Senior Thesis, Princeton University, 2017

"Reinterpreting the Volcker Disinflation: the Anti-Inflationary Resolve (or Lack Thereof) of the Federal Open Market Committee during Paul Volcker's First Year of Chairmanship, August 1979-July 1980" – Junior Paper, Princeton University, 2016

"Workers' Demonstrations and Liberals' Condemnations: the Italian Liberal Press's Coverage of General Strikes, Factory Occupations, and Workers' Self-Defense Groups during the Rise of Fascism, 1919-1922" – *Chicago Journal of History*, Issue 6, 2016, pp. 29-43.